Clinical App Builder / GitHub Projects

Guideline-to-App Playbook

How physician expertise becomes usable software

Series 1 of 3

Clear promise: A step-by-step framework for turning a clinical guideline into a simple educational or decision-support app.

Part of the Doctors Who Code lead magnet series for physician-builders.

Guide 1 of 3

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Table of contents

Why some guidelines need software

Many guidelines are accurate but operationally hard to use. They were written for reading, not for fast application in a live workflow. That gap is where software can help.

A strong micro-app makes the underlying logic easier to access, teach, and apply. It does not replace judgment. It improves usability.

Choosing the right guideline

Choose guidance that has clear thresholds, recognizable inputs, repeatable decisions, and meaningful teaching value. The best source material is clinically important but structurally awkward in day-to-day use.

Avoid starting with guidance that is too ambiguous, too broad, or too dependent on context that cannot be represented safely.

Extracting decision logic

Most guidelines hide their actual decision points inside prose. Your first job is to expose the structure. What inputs matter. What thresholds change the recommendation. What branches exist. What cautions and exceptions need to survive translation.

This is physician work before it is programming work. You are converting narrative expertise into explicit logic without flattening its meaning.

Turning narrative recommendations into app flow

Once the logic is clear, design the sequence the user will move through. Keep the inputs simple, the branches obvious, and the outputs readable. If a recommendation depends on a threshold, make that threshold visible. If uncertainty remains, say so plainly.

The user should feel that the app clarifies the guideline, not that it hides it.

Validation and caution

A good guideline app does not pretend to be self-authenticating. It cites its source, states its scope, and invites review. It makes caution visible where caution belongs.

Validation should include content review, usability review, and edge-case testing before public release.